

BY: ASHA-KAY NEVENE ROBERTS



# A DAUGHTER FROM HERAT: THE JOURNEY OF MARZIA.

This book tells the powerful and inspiring story of Marzia, a woman who fought for freedom and justice in Herat, Afghanistan, and began a journey filled with both hardship and hope, guided by her strength and determination. From the streets of Herat to a new life in Iran, France, and finally Canada, Marzia faced threats and dangers, loss and grief, and cultural and linguistic barriers. She is defined not only as a lawyer and women's rights advocate but also as a loving wife, a newcomer, and ultimately a strong woman who continues to move forward. This book is a story of loss and discovery, resilience and endurance, and a spirit that refuses to surrender. "A Daughter from Herat: The Journey of Marzia" takes you into the heart of a brave woman who never gave up hope, despite the adversities life threw her way.

This book is available in two languages: English and Farsi.

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# 1

## CHAPTER

### INTRODUCTION TO MARZIA AND HESSAM

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Marzia was a woman of strength and conviction. At 48 years old, she had spent much of her life in Herat, Afghanistan, fighting for women's rights as a lawyer. Her work was challenging, dangerous, and often thankless. Every day, she faced threats from the Taliban, who viewed her activism as a direct challenge to their authority. Despite the danger, Marzia continued to work tirelessly, driven by a deep belief in justice and equality.

Hessam, 36, was a journalist and news photographer, capturing the stark realities of life in Afghanistan with a lens that sought truth above all else. He was full of energy and eager to learn, always on the move, driven by a passion for storytelling and a desire to make a difference. They met in 2012, and their love blossomed amid the turmoil of their homeland. By 2014, they were married, united not only by their love but also by their shared commitment to truth and justice.

# 2

CHAPTER

## FLEEING AFGHANISTAN

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Their lives were turned upside down in August 2021 when the Taliban took over Afghanistan. The streets of Herat, once bustling with life, were now filled with fear. With the Taliban's return, the threats against Marzia grew more severe, and Hessam's work as a journalist put him in grave danger. The couple knew they had to flee.

Together, they made a harrowing journey to Iran, leaving behind everything they had ever known.

For a year, they lived in Damavand, a small town near Tehran, with Marzia's sister and her family. It was a time of uncertainty and fear, but also of resilience. Hessam's work for Deutsche Welle opened a door for them to resettle in France.

With hope in their hearts and sadness for what they left behind, they moved to a small town near Paris, seeking safety and a new beginning.

# 3

CHAPTER

## CHALLENGES IN FRANCE

# CHALLENGES IN FRANCE

Life in France was not easy. The language barrier was a constant struggle, making everyday tasks a challenge. The cultural differences were vast, and Marzia and Hessam often felt isolated and alone. Financial hardship added another layer of difficulty to their new life. They lived modestly, carefully budgeting every euro as they navigated their new reality.

Despite these challenges, Marzia and Hessam found strength in each other. Marzia, who had always been a fighter, took each day as it came, determined to build a new life. Hessam, with his youthful energy and optimism, encouraged her to keep going. Together, they faced the daily challenges of life in a foreign country, supporting each other through every setback.

# 4

CHAPTER

## NEW BEGINNINGS IN CANADA

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In February 2023, another opportunity presented itself. Marzia had worked on a project in Herat for a Canadian organization, and she saw a chance for them to move to Canada. With proof of her work and the support of the Canadian government, they were able to resettle in Vancouver. It was a new beginning, filled with hope.

In Vancouver, they found a small apartment and began to rebuild their lives once more. Hessam's sister, who lived nearby, offered support and a sense of family. Marzia started learning English, determined to overcome the language barrier that had held her back in France. She decided to pursue a career in early childhood education, a field that would allow her to continue working with children, something she had always been passionate about. With determination, she earned her certifications and began planning to open a home daycare center.

# NEW BEGINNINGS IN CANADA

Hessam found work at an Amazon warehouse, taking on additional jobs as a food delivery driver to make ends meet. He still dreamed of returning to journalism, but for now, he focused on supporting Marzia and building their new life together. They even managed to save enough money to buy a car, a small but significant victory in their journey.

# 5

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## HESSAM'S ILLNESS

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Just as things were beginning to settle, Hessam started experiencing severe pain in his teeth. After visiting a dentist, they received devastating news. A full-mouth X-ray revealed several glands under his teeth and jaw, and further tests confirmed it was cancer. Their world, once again, was turned upside down.

From August 2023 to July 2024, their lives revolved around hospitals and doctors' offices. Hessam underwent surgery to remove the tumors, followed by a grueling series of chemotherapy treatments. Despite their best efforts, the prognosis was bleak. Hessam chose to keep his condition a secret from his parents, not wanting to burden them with worry. He had already lost a brother to the Taliban five years earlier and did not want to add to their grief.

# HESSAM'S ILLNESS

Marzia stood by him every step of the way, her strength unwavering even as she watched the love of her life fade away. She tried to hold onto hope, but as Hessam's condition worsened, she knew that the end was near. On July 2nd, 2024, Hessam passed away, leaving Marzia alone in a foreign land, her heart shattered by grief.

# 6

CHAPTER

## GRIEVING AND GOODBYE

# GRIEVING AND GOODBYE

Hessam's parents, who were living in Australia, arrived just in time to say their final goodbyes. They were heartbroken and angry, struggling to understand why they hadn't been told of their son's condition. Marzia, in her sorrow, explained that Hessam himself had not wanted them to know. His last wish was to be buried in Herat, his hometown, alongside his brother. His father, determined to honor his son's wishes, accompanied Hessam's body back to Afghanistan, vowing to remain there until his own death, so he could be buried next to his sons.

# 7

CHAPTER

## ALONE AND ADRIFT

# ALONE AND ADRIFT

With Hessam gone, Marzia found herself utterly alone. She had lost her husband, her love, and her support system. Financially, she was in dire straits, with no income and no family nearby to help her. Her mental health deteriorated, and she lost a significant amount of weight. Her cousin in Toronto, understanding her plight, bought her a ticket to Iran and offered her a place to stay for a week before she made the journey.

Marzia was reluctant to leave Canada, despite the pain it held for her. She was afraid to return to the apartment in Vancouver, filled with memories of Hessam and their life together. Her family in Iran tried to encourage her, hoping she would eventually return to Canada and stay near her cousin in Toronto. But for now, Marzia was lost, her future uncertain.

# 8

CHAPTER

## REFLECTION AND RESILIENCE

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In Iran, Marzia reflected on her life and the many losses she had endured. She thought of her mother, who had died of cancer in 2022, and her father, who had been killed during the Russian invasion of Afghanistan. She remembered her miscarriages and the pain of not being able to have children. Each memory was a wound that seemed to never heal, but Marzia knew she had to keep going. She had survived so much already, and she was determined to find a way forward, even if she didn't know what that would look like.

# 9

CHAPTER

AN OPEN ENDING

# AN OPEN ENDING

As her three-month visitor visa neared its end, Marzia faced a decision. Would she return to Canada and try to rebuild her life once more, this time in Toronto near her cousin? Or would she remain in Iran, surrounded by her family but haunted by her memories and losses? The future was uncertain, but one thing was clear: Marzia was a survivor. She had faced unimaginable hardships and had come through each one with a strength that few possessed. Whatever lay ahead, Marzia knew she would face it with the same courage and resilience that had carried her this far.

# 10

CHAPTER

END OF BOOK

# END OF BOOK

This structure offers a compelling narrative arc that captures Marzia's journey, showcasing her strength and resilience through every phase of her life. This story is based on real events, with names changed to protect the individuals' privacy.

**THANK YOU FOR  
READING**

